where the dam was to be built (in order to blow up the nearby mountains to build the dam), Khan arranged for the explosives from a Central Asian country.[127]

Having agreed to build the dam at Karzai's request, India was caught in the bilateral rivalry. On 28 February 2005, then Iranian foreign minister Kamal Kharazi officially complained to Manmohan Singh about India's decision to build the dam, only to be told to discuss the matter with Kabul rather than drag India into it.[128] Indeed, in April 2007, Tehran pressured visiting Afghan foreign minister Rangin Dafdar Spanta to reach an acceptable water sharing agreement, only to be deflected by the latter.[129] While nothing changed for the coming years, reports of Iranian attempts to sabotage the project occasionally hit the local Herati newswires. Then, in 2011, Khare came across highly specific intelligence inputs that members of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) were determined to destroy the dam using proxy forces.[130] He refused to believe that Tehran would give such a direction against a project built by India. But soon afterwards, in 2012, Iran's ambassador to Afghanistan undertook a protest march to the Indian embassy in Kabul demanding a halt in construction of the dam.[131] On the ground, allegedly, Iran had begun to manipulate local powerbrokers in Herat to slow down, if not sabotage, the construction of the dam. In October of same year, for instance, the battalion commander of the Herat Police testified that local anti-government commander Mullah Mustafa (of the nearby Ghor province who operated in Chest-e-Sharif), who had strong support from Ismael Khan, was being financed by Iran to oppose the construction of the dam.[132]

A double game was on. On the one hand, Mullah Mustafa and other local Herati power brokers wanted the dam to be built, but on the other hand, they threatened peaceful construction as a stick to negotiate power and patronage with Herat. Not surprisingly, Indian consular officials got along well with Mullah Mustafa, but were equally wary of him (were he to decide on sabotaging the construction of the dam). On one occasion, in fact, Mullah Mustafa had secured the release of a kidnapped Indian worker from a local Taliban unit within two days.[133] But, in order to maintain his power in Chest-e-Sharif, he pushed Ahmad Yusuf Nuristani, the then governor of Heart, in March 2009 to change the district governor of Chest-e-Sharif, or else he would not allow peaceful construction of the dam.[134] That Ismael Khan supported Mullah Mustafa